of the current weakness of the monitoring and surveillance capabilities of the BRICS themselves.[119] However, some critics question whether the CRA has "the requisite firepower," in that it is equivalent to about 1 percent of China's reserves or 80 percent of India's budget deficit for the 2013–2014 fiscal year. Although it might help South Africa, Brazil's 2002 bailout rose to $30.4 billion.[120]

These new BRICS institutions give the club credibility in global economic governance, and the members were eager to go operational. In April 2016, after caucusing on the sidelines of the World Bank/IMF spring meeting in Washington, the NDB's board of directors announced that its first loans would go to four of the five BRICS countries (i.e., all but Russia), and that all would target the renewable energy sector, "supporting 2,370 megawatts" of capacity.[121] Later, at the July board meeting, a loan to support the construction of two hydropower generation plants with a total installed capacity of 49.8 megawatts in the Republic of Karelia in the Russian Federation was also approved.[122]

The loans would be issued in U.S. dollars and would go to established banks in each country with long experience in infrastructure project finance, and thence be passed on to their ultimate loan recipients, although the Russian loan would be in coordination with the Eurasian Development Bank. They were relatively small, with all four loans summing to only $911 million, but their importance was clearly symbolic on multiple levels, including in the sense that they were supposed to address the NDB's twin goals of infrastructure and "sustainable development," the latter a goal especially important to domestic constituencies in Brazil and India.

Then, in late June 2016, NDB President Kamath took another step that was arguably more important: he announced plans to issue bonds in national currencies to attract private capital within the BRICS countries.[123] The first Green Financial Bond issuance was in China's onshore bond market, with an issue size of 3 billion RMB at a nominal interest rate of 3.07 percent. Leslie Maasdorp, the South African chief financial officer of the NDB, expects that the bank will become a frequent issuer in the Chinese interbank market. Two Chinese rating firms, China Chengxin Credit Rating Group and China Lianhe Credit Rating Co., have assigned their highest (AAA) rating to the bank, but ratings from the American "Big Three" (Moody's, S&P, and Fitch) are pending at the time of writing.[124] It will not be triple-A, however, given China's AA sovereign rating from S&P and the other countries' scores in the